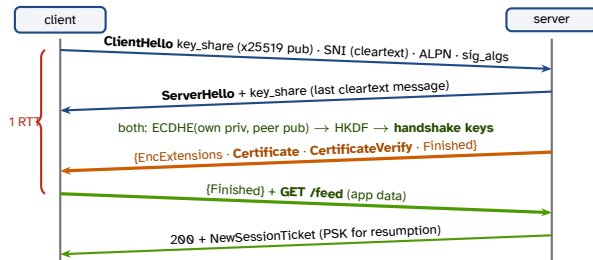


In one line: TLS gives **confidentiality** (AEAD), **integrity** and **server authentication**: an **ephemeral ECDHE** exchange makes the keys (forward secrecy), and a **certificate chain** ending in a root the device already trusts proves the key belongs to the **hostname**. TLS 1.3 (RFC 8446) does it in **1 RTT**; resumption can send data in **0 RTT** — replayable.

TLS 1.3 full handshake (1-RTT)



[...] = encrypted. CertificateVerify = signature over the transcript with the leaf's private key.

0-RTT: ClientHello + psk + early_data carries app data at once; it is keyed from the resumption PSK only — **replayable**, no forward secrecy for that data.

Chain of trust (X.509, RFC 5280)



Missing intermediate: some clients fetch it via AIA or have it cached → “works in Safari, fails in curl / Android / the app” — fix the server, not the client.

How it works

- Key exchange:** each side sends an *ephemeral* ECDHE public key; the shared secret feeds HKDF → handshake, then traffic keys. The certificate key only **signs** (CertificateVerify) — it never encrypts a secret.
- Forward secrecy:** ephemeral keys are discarded, so a server key stolen later *cannot* decrypt recorded sessions. 1.2 static-RSA key transport had no FS.
- 1.3 suites** name only AEAD + hash: TLS_AES_128_GCM_SHA256, TLS_AES_256_GCM_SHA384, TLS_CHACHA20_POLY1305_SHA256. Group (x25519, P-256) and signature (ECDSA, RSA-PSS, Ed25519) are negotiated separately; a 1.2 suite bundled all four (ECDHE-RSA-AES128-GCM-SHA256).
- Wrong key_share guess → **HelloRetryRequest** → 2 RTT. Resumption: ticket → PSK; PSK + fresh ECDHE keeps FS, 0-RTT data does not.

TLS 1.2 (RFC 5246) vs 1.3

	1.2	1.3
handshake	2 RTT (Hello → KeyExchange + Finished)	1 RTT; 0-RTT on resumption
key exchange	RSA transport or (EC)DHE sent in cleartext	(EC)DHE only: FS mandatory encrypted
certificate removed	—	RSA kx, CBC, RC4, SHA-1, compression, renegotiation

Validation — what SecTrust checks

- Path** leaf → intermediates → a root in the trust store; **signature** at every link; intermediates CA: TRUE.
- Validity:** notBefore ≤ now ≤ notAfter — the *device clock*.
- Hostname vs SAN** (iOS 13+: CN ignored; EKU serverAuth, RSA ≥ 2048, SHA-2).
- Revocation:** CRL (list) · OCSP (live query, leaks who you visit) · **stapling** (server attaches a signed OCSP answer). Clients **soft-fail:** blocked responder = pass. Let's Encrypt ended OCSP in 2025 (CRLs).
- CT** (RFC 6962): public append-only logs; Apple requires SCTs. Then **your policy:** ATS, pins — *after* default validation, never instead.

Example — mTLS: answer the client-certificate challenge

```
func URLSession(_ s: URLSession, didReceive c: URLAuthenticationChallenge)
    async -> (URLSession.AuthChallengeDisposition, URLCredential?) {
    switch c.protectionSpace.authenticationMethod {
    case NSURLAuthenticationMethodClientCertificate:
        let id = keychainIdentity() // SecIdentity = cert + private key
        return (.useCredential, URLCredential(identity: id,
            certificates: nil, persistence: .forSession))
        default:
            // server trust: keep default checks
            return (.performDefaultHandling, nil)
    }
}
```

Related: urlsession-networking (pinning code) · keychain-secure-enclave · app-hardening-privacy (ATS) · http-deep (QUIC carries TLS 1.3) · oauth-oidc-jwt

Pinning — what to pin

Pin	Survives	Risk
leaf cert	nothing: every renewal	bricks old binaries every 90 days
leaf SPKI	renewal with same key	key compromise → backup pin
interm. SPKI	any leaf re-key by that CA	CA rotates its intermediate
root SPKI	almost everything	weak: any leaf of that CA passes

Always ≥ 2 pins: current + an **offline backup key**. No code: NSPinnedDomains → NSPinnedLeafIdentities / NSPinnedCAIdentities (SPKI-SHA256-BASE64). Have a kill path (pins in remote config) or accept a forced update.

mTLS and ATS

mTLS: server sends CertificateRequest; client answers Certificate + CertificateVerify — proves *possession of a key*, no bearer secret on the wire. Cost: issuing + rotating a per-device cert (SecPKCS12Import of a .p12). **ATS:** HTTPS, TLS ≥ 1.2, FS suites, valid chain; narrow NSExceptionDomains; NSAllowsArbitraryLoads needs a review reason.

Failures you actually meet

missing intermediate	browser OK, others fail: serve the full chain
expired root / cross-sign	DST Root CA X3 (30 Sep 2021) broke old devices
device clock wrong	-1201 bad date · -1204 not yet valid
name not in SAN	-1202 server certificate untrusted
private CA / self-signed	-1203 unknown root: trust the root, not the leaf
http: // under ATS	-1022 (ATS requires a secure connection)
proxy / captive portal	MITM certificate: pinning fails, as designed

URLError names checked; the numeric codes (*unverified*).

Traps

- ! “Disable validation for testing” ships a MITM: encryption to the *attacker*. Use a test CA.
- ! 0-RTT is not free speed: early data is **replayable** — idempotent GETs only.
- ! A DV cert proves *domain control at issuance*, not honesty.
- ! SNI leaks the hostname in cleartext; ECH closes it.
- ! SecKeyCopyExternalRepresentation gives the *raw* key, not SPKI — prepend the ASN.1 header before hashing or the pin never matches.

Remember

“Ephemeral keys encrypt, certificates sign, the chain proves the name.”